meant to be the real power centre of the UPA government. The core group members included the prime minister, Pranab Mukherjee (before he became President), Chidambaram, A.K. Antony, Sushil Shinde and Ahmed Patel. None of them were vote-catching leaders—almost all of them owed their place to their proximity to the Congress's First Family.

Patel is an interesting character who exemplifies how the Congress has become a 'drawing room' party that relies on deal-making. A Rajya Sabha MP from Gujarat, he was a key power centre. A silent, almost shadowy figure rarely seen on camera, he was Sonia's political secretary, expected to handle the 'dirty business' of crisis management in politics. 'The rest of us work by day, Ahmed Patel works in the night,' was how one Congressman laughingly described Patel's modus operandi. For most journalists trying to penetrate the Congress's interlinked durbars, Patel was a gold mine—he gave us the '*andar ki khabar*', but never wanted to be quoted or come on camera.

The core group was meant to ensure greater coordination between the Congress party and the government. It was seen as a repository of all political wisdom. And yet, it was this very core group that created further headaches for both the party and the government. It mishandled the Anna agitation. It sent its ministers to meet Ramdev. It endorsed the breaking up of Andhra Pradesh. It even approved the ordinance that would give convicted lawmakers a reprieve.

The core group also could not stop the party and the government from speaking in different voices. The first sign of this came as early as July 2009, barely two months into the life of the new government. The prime minister had gone to Sharm el-Sheikh where, on the sidelines of the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) summit, he had signed a joint statement with his Pakistani counterpart Yusuf Raza Gilani to cooperate on fighting terror. Born in Pakistan, Dr Singh had always been keen on breaking the ice with Islamabad. Empowered by a strong mandate in the elections, he thought this was the ideal moment to make a fresh effort at peace—it could even be a Nobel Prize-winning achievement.